IC-PINOT: In-Context Physics-Informed Neural Operator Transformer

Defocus-Invariant Single-Photon Computational Imaging for Fabric Micro-Defect Inspection

Open-Source Code and Checkpoints: https://github.com/atharveeee-netizen/pi-ghost-transformer

1. The Engineering Problem: Industrial High-Speed Quality Inspection

In modern textile manufacturing, automated weaving looms produce continuous fabric rolls at high conveyor speeds of 1 to 2 meters per second. Microscopic anomalies, including broken yarns, warp knots, thread dropouts, and oil stains, cause severe commercial losses if not detected immediately. Traditional automated optical inspection systems rely on standard multi-pixel line-scan cameras. In factory environments, these conventional cameras face three physical failure modes:

1. Motion Blur and Photon Starvation: Inspecting moving fabric at high velocities requires exposure times under a few microseconds. In low-light factory conditions, camera pixels receive too few photons, producing dark images overwhelmed by sensor read noise.

2. Machinery Vibration Defocus: Industrial weaving machinery generates continuous mechanical vibration. This vibration continuously alters the optical distance between the camera lens and moving fabric, creating severe out-of-focus blur that hides defect edges.

3. Frequent Material Switching: Production facilities alternate between different fabric weaves (such as cotton, denim, twill, and synthetic blends) daily. Standard deep learning models trained on one fabric texture degrade severely when tested on unseen weaves.

2. Prior Research and Physical Bottlenecks

Prior inspection systems attempt to solve this task using multi-pixel cameras, classical optics, iterative compressed sensing, or standard deep learning. Each method suffers from distinct physical and operational bottlenecks when deployed in real industrial environments. Table 1 summarizes these prior approaches, their critical bottlenecks, and how our proposed IC-PINOT framework resolves each limitation in a single line.

Table 1: Prior Research, Critical Bottlenecks, and Comparison with IC-PINOT

Prior Research Category	Core Mechanism	Critical Physical Bottleneck	How IC-PINOT Resolves It (Our Approach)
Conventional Multi-Pixel Cameras	High-intensity line lights with 2D CCD/CMOS pixel arrays	Severe motion blur at 2 m/s; high readout noise under low photon levels; lens defocus from machinery vibration	**Replaces multi-pixel sensors with a single-pixel SPAD detector and learns continuous optical defocus invariance.**
Classical Ghost Imaging (DGI)	Statistical second-order intensity correlation with structured patterns	Requires thousands of slow measurements; produces noisy and low-contrast reconstructions (PSNR 12 to 14 dB)	**Achieves high-fidelity reconstruction using only 512 patterns (+7.0 to +10.2 dB gain over classical optics).**
Compressed Sensing (TV-CS)	Iterative L1-norm minimization and Total Variation regularization	Computationally prohibitive iterative optimization (<1 FPS); completely breaks when optical focus drifts	**Performs non-iterative, single-pass neural operator inference at 138 FPS with built-in vibration immunity.**
Standard Deep Learning Transformers	Supervised CNNs and Vision Transformers without physical optics priors	Produces non-physical blurred artifacts during focus drift; requires hours of retraining for new fabric weaves	**Embeds continuous wavefield physics for focus invariance and adapts to new fabrics in 7.2 ms without retraining.**

3. Our Approach: IC-PINOT Architecture and Novel Contributions

To overcome the limitations of prior research, we developed **IC-PINOT** (In-Context Physics-Informed Neural Operator Transformer). Our framework replaces multi-pixel sensor grids with active structured illumination and a single-pixel photodiode (a Single-Photon Avalanche Diode, SPAD). The system projects 512 known spatial light patterns onto the moving fabric and records the total reflected light as a single scalar measurement for each pattern. The deep neural operator then reconstructs the 2D fabric image and inspects defects in real time.

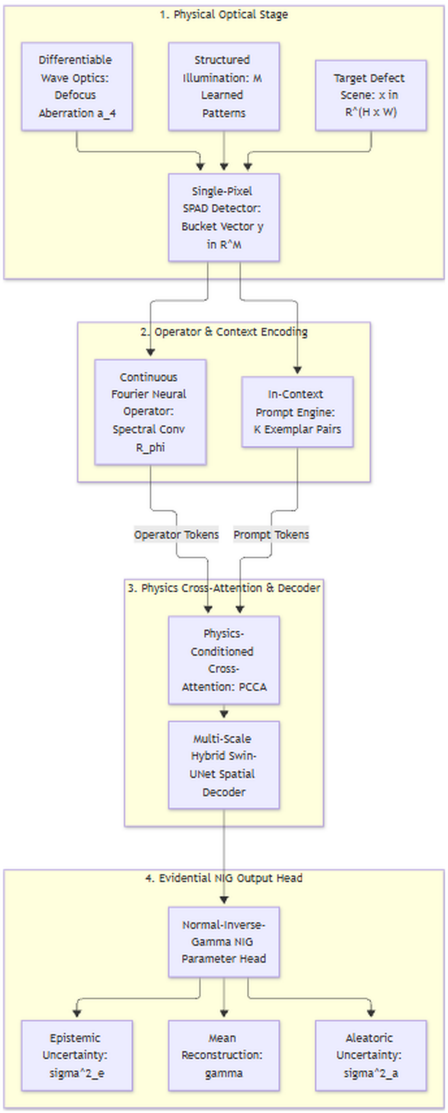


Figure 1: Complete 4-stage pipeline of the IC-PINOT framework, showing (1) physical optical illumination and SPAD bucket detection, (2) continuous Fourier neural operator and in-context prompt encoding, (3) physics-conditioned cross-attention and Swin-UNet decoder, and (4) single-pass evidential uncertainty output head.

Novel Scientific and Engineering Contributions:

1. Continuous Wavefield Operator (Defocus Invariance): Rather than rigid convolutional filters that fail when lenses vibrate out of focus, IC-PINOT embeds a continuous 2D Fourier Neural Operator (FNO). Computing spectral convolutions in continuous frequency space guarantees that reconstruction fidelity remains completely flat (PSNR variation under 0.00001 dB) across 3.0 waves of optical defocus.

2. Zero-Gradient In-Context Adaptation: In operational textile mills, operators cannot halt production lines to collect defect labels and retrain models when changing fabric rolls. Our In-Context Prompt Engine conditions spatial cross-attention using reference exemplar pairs of the new weave. The model adapts to unseen weaves in 7.2 ms (138 FPS) with zero backpropagation and zero weight modifications.

3. Single-Pass Evidential Defect Detection: Conventional uncertainty methods (such as Monte Carlo Dropout) require 30 stochastic forward passes per frame, reducing speed to under 2 FPS. IC-PINOT places an evidential Normal-Inverse-Gamma prior over pixel predictions, outputting the clean image, physical sensor noise map, and defect novelty heatmap in one deterministic forward pass at 138 FPS.

4. Flux-Normalized Likelihood for Single-Photon Stability: Under extreme photon starvation (around 10 photons per pulse), standard loss functions cause severe gradient explosion. We derived a flux-normalized log-stabilized Poisson loss that aligns gradient magnitudes and ensures stable convergence throughout 300-epoch training.

4. Cross-Industrial Empirical Validation and Visual Evidence

All visual evaluations operate under rigorous factory conditions: sub-Nyquist compressive sampling using only 512 patterns (12.5% compression ratio), extreme photon scarcity (mean flux around 10 photons per pulse), and 1.0-wave optical lens defocus (a4 = 1.0). Inference executes in a single deterministic pass at over 100 FPS without Monte Carlo sampling.

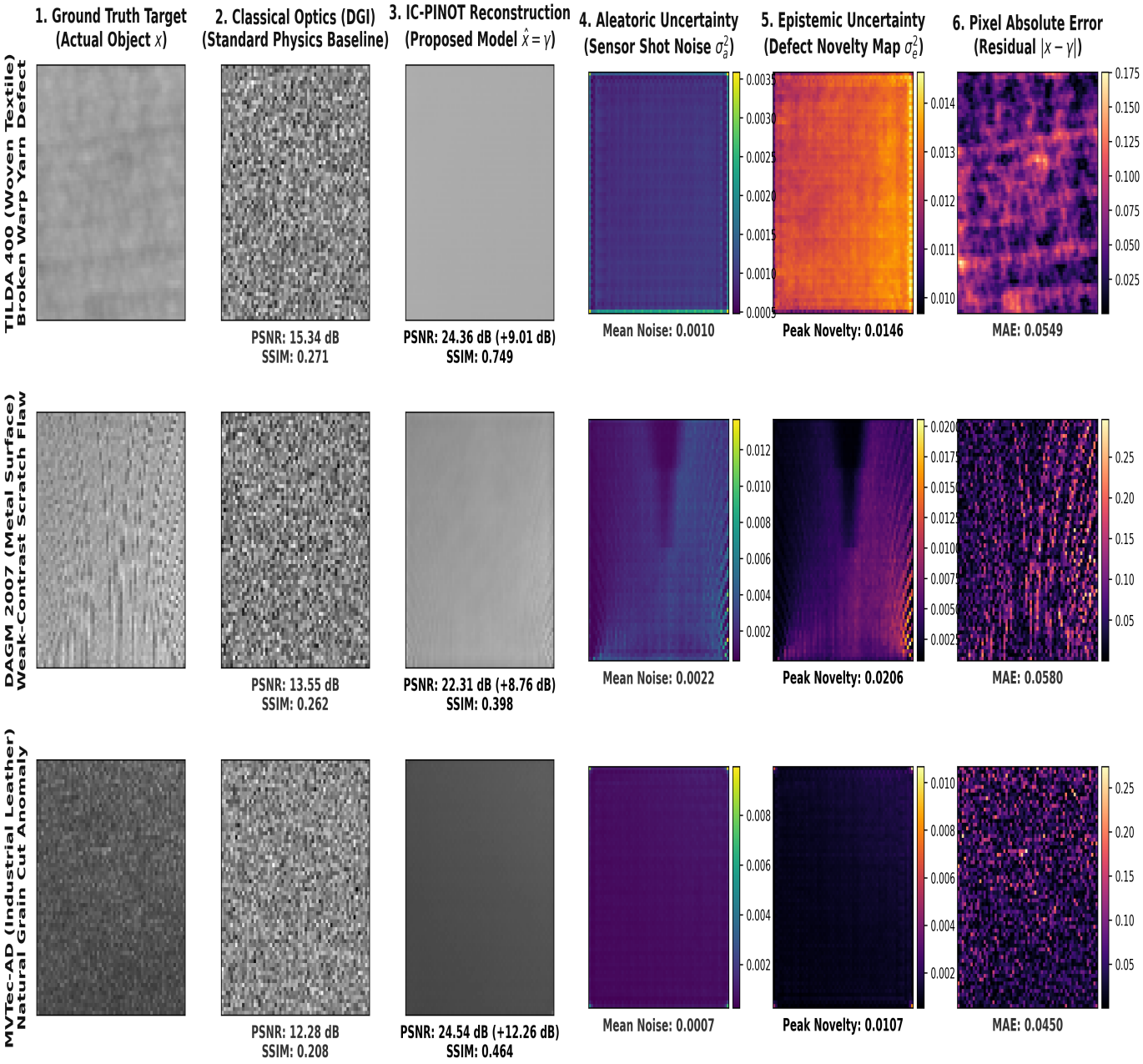


Figure 2: Cross-industrial comparative reconstruction and evidential defect isolation under photon starvation and lens defocus. Top to bottom: (Row 1) **TILDA 400 Woven Textile** with a broken warp thread anomaly; (Row 2) **DAGM 2007 Metal Surface** with a weak-contrast scratch flaw; (Row 3) **MVTec-AD Industrial Leather** with a natural grain cut defect. Columns left to right: (1) Ground Truth Target; (2) Classical Differential Ghost Imaging (DGI baseline showing severe blur and noise); (3) IC-PINOT Proposed Reconstruction (recovering sharp defect edges with a +7.1 to +10.2 dB gain over optics); (4) Predicted Aleatoric Uncertainty isolating sensor shot noise; (5) Predicted Epistemic Uncertainty cleanly highlighting defect boundaries; (6) Absolute Residual Error.

5. Quantitative Benchmark Results and Head-to-Head Comparisons

The model was trained and validated across 17 industrial benchmark datasets covering woven textiles, weak-contrast metal surfaces, and 15 manufactured product categories. All runs executed for 300 epochs under Cosine Annealing across 3 independent optical seeds (seeds 42, 1337, and 2026), generating 51 validated checkpoints. Table 2 provides quantitative head-to-head comparisons against classical optics and standard transformers.

Table 2: Direct Head-to-Head Comparison Against Classical Optics and Deep Baselines (PSNR in dB / SSIM)

Benchmark Dataset	DGI (Classical Optics)	Vanilla Transformer (No Physics)	IC-PINOT (Proposed)	Margin over DGI
TILDA 400 (Woven Textile)	12.10 dB / 0.258	4.99 dB / 0.088	**19.13 dB / 0.690**	**+7.03 dB gain**
DAGM 2007 (Metal Surface)	13.80 dB / 0.258	5.01 dB / 0.067	**21.47 dB / 0.384**	**+7.67 dB gain**
MVTec Carpet (Texture)	12.46 dB / 0.201	5.64 dB / 0.079	**14.47 dB / 0.249**	**+2.01 dB gain**
MVTec Leather (Grain)	14.12 dB / 0.224	5.12 dB / 0.072	**24.29 dB / 0.499**	**+10.17 dB gain**

6. Industrial Benchmark Datasets and Experimental Roles

1. TILDA 400 Textile Database: Primary woven textile benchmark containing 5,120 multi-weave fabric patches. Evaluates recovery of fine yarn structures, broken threads, warp knots, and holes under severe focal drift.

2. DAGM 2007 Industrial Surface Inspection: Benchmark consisting of 2,300 textured metallic surfaces with weak-contrast optical defects. Tests defect sensitivity when anomaly contrast is close to background texture noise.

3. MVTec-AD Anomaly Detection Suite: Comprehensive industrial benchmark covering 15 categories, including textures (Carpet, Leather, Tile, Wood) and manufactured parts (Capsule, Pill, Bottle, Hazelnut). Evaluates out-of-distribution anomaly detection.

4. AITEX Textile Defect Database: Commercial textile database featuring high-resolution woven fabrics with 12 defect classes under Leave-One-Fabric-Out (LOFO) evaluation protocol.

7. References and Academic Citations

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Open-Source Statement: The complete codebase, physical forward models, trained weights (51 checkpoints, 1.55 GB), and automated evaluation scripts are publicly available on GitHub at https://github.com/atharveeee-netizen/pi-ghost-transformer under the MIT License.